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COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

NEW STATE RECORD ☒UNUSUAL RECORD ☐

Please print or type. Attach photographs and additional pages if necessary.

Species: Henslow's Sparrow (Vernacular Name) Ammodramus henslowi (Scientific Name)Date(s): 9/10/85Number of birds seen: 1 Sex: ? Plumage: AdultLocality: Jackson Res. Intake Canal by Pelican Refuge Elevation: 4350 ftNearest town: Goodrich, Colo. County: MorganTime(s) observed: 11:30 AM.Duration of observation (e.g. 1 sec., 5 min., etc.): 2 minutes (total)

Other observers who saw the bird with you (give names, addresses, telephone numbers):

Laurens Halsey, 6422 Bluebird Ave, Longmont, Colo., 80501 530-1628Jack Reddick, 4450 S. Arden, Englewood, Colo., 80111, 771-5308

Other observers who saw the bird independently (give names, addresses, telephone numbers)

Light conditions (position of bird to light and shade, direction and strength of light):

Overcast - but well lit by diffuse sunlightOptical equipment used (e.g. power, types): Bushnell 10X50 Binocs, Bushnell Sparmaster Spotting scopeDistance, and how measured: Estimate 20 ydsIf photographed, type of equipment and film: —Who else photographed the bird? — (GHW)

Describe the bird's behavior (e.g. flying, feeding, or habits used in identifying):

The bird sat for 30 sec & then 1 min 30 sec on a barbed wire fence no feeding was observed. the bird faced us and appeared to be alert.

Describe in detail the bird's relative size, overall shape, plumage and color pattern. Include details of bill, wing and tail shape. Give particular emphasis to marks you used to identify the bird. Reference to its resemblance to field guide descriptions and illustrations is not enough. Describe only what you actually observe in the field:

A large billed flat headed "stocky" sparrow with a short-tapered tail. 2 whisker stripes and a black ear mark were observed on an olive face. The bird showed brown lateral crown stripes with an olive median stripe which extended onto the nape to form an olive collar. Fine streaking in a narrow horizontal band extended across a buff upper breast. Fine streaks (1 column) extended down

Description (continued): the buffy sides. Underparts (belly, lower breast) were light buff to white towards the vent. The birds upper back was dark with small white flecks. The rump, upper side of tail and wings were difficult to observe due to the fact that the bird faced me - however, in flight, they seemed brownish to brownish red.

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery, (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration):

Bird Silent.

Describe the general and specific habitat in which you observed the bird:

The bird sat on a fence bordering a field of mixed grasses extending from 1ft to 4 ft in height.

How did you eliminate similarly appearing species? The structure of the bird (being "stocky", flat headed and with short tapered tail) place the bird in Ammodramus.

The large bill suggests Henslow's, Olive nape rules out Baird's sparrow. Lack of white crown stripe, large bill, whisker stripes eliminate Leconte's. Strong facial markings and olive nape eliminate Grasshopper. Double whisker & nape eliminate sharp-tail (also no white lines on upper back were observed). If structure is insufficient to rule out Lincoln's, swamp and savannah, the combination of whisker marks, crown stripes & nape, are.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly appearing species?
Have seen: 6 Henslow's - total observation time: 1.5 hr on Konza Prairie in Kans.
1 Leconte's - " " : 2 min. Eastern KS.

2000. praterensis & praterpallidus Grasshopper sparrows (adults + juveniles + immatures): over 2 hrs; praterensis in Eastern U.S.
1 Baird's - 15 min - Pawnee Grasslands praterpallidus in Colo.

None with Sharptailed - Have seen several notes, savannah song (adults + imm.), 30 swamps (ad. + imm.)
List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: Laurens Halsey, Jack Reddall,
books: National Geographic Guide

b) after observation: Audubon Master Guide + skins at museum

This report was written from reports made during ✓, after observation from memory
Date and time report was written: Jan 12, 1986

Reporting observer: Wade Leitner Signature: Wade Leitner

Address: 14079 E. Stanford Cr. Aurora, Colo, 80015

All reports will be maintained permanently at the address below:

Return to:

CURATOR, DEPARTMENT OF ZOOLOGICAL COLLECTIONS
DENVER MUSEUM OF NATURAL HISTORY
CITY PARK
DENVER, CO 80205

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COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

NEW STATE RECORD ☒UNUSUAL RECORD ☐

Please print or type. Attach photographs and additional pages if necessary.

Species: Henslow's Sparrow Ammodramus henslowi
(Vernacular Name) (Scientific Name)Date(s): September 10, 1985Number of birds seen: one Sex: undetermined Plumage: adultLocality: Jackson Reservoir, intake canal Elevation: ~4350'Nearest town: Goodrich, Colorado County: MorganTime(s) observed: approximately 11:30 amDuration of observation (e.g. 1 sec., 5 min., etc.): 2 minutes totalOther observers who saw the bird with you (give names, addresses, telephone numbers):
Wade Leitner 14079 E. Stanford Cr. Aurora, Colo., 80015 699-7281Jack Readall 4450 S. Atton Way, Englewood, Colo., 80111 771-5708

Other observers who saw the bird independently (give names, addresses, telephone numbers)

Light conditions (position of bird to light and shade, direction and strength of light):

Bright overcast, good viewingOptical equipment used (e.g. power, types): 7x50 Binocs, 20 to 45x ScopeDistance, and how measured: estimated, 15 metersIf photographed, type of equipment and film: N/AWho else photographed the bird? N/ADescribe the bird's behavior (e.g. flying, feeding, or habits used in identifying):
Appeared on fence, sat for approximately 30 seconds, flew into grass, returned to fence for approximately 90 seconds, after which it flew into grass. No feeding or other type behavior observed.Describe in detail the bird's relative size, overall shape, plumage and color pattern. Include details of bill, wing and tail shape. Give particular emphasis to marks you used to identify the bird. Reference to its resemblance to field guide descriptions and illustrations is not enough. Describe only what you actually observe in the field:
Typical ammodramus shaped. Flat headed, short and narrow tail, overall short stocky sparrow. Large billed for ammodramus. Buff olive face with two black whisker marks and dark ear patch. Two brown lateral crown stripes with an olive median crown stripe, which continued and widened on the nape giving the appearance of an olive hindneck. Chin clear and white. Upper breast had fine black streaks on a buffy background, extending

Description (continued):

down the sides. The rest of the underparts clear and pale buff. The back appeared dark brown, with many white spots (white tips or edges to feathers).

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery, (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration): none heard

Describe the general, and specific habitat in which you observed the bird:
Edge of large mixed grass field, 1/2 to 1 meter height.

How did you eliminate similarly appearing species?

Lincoln's Sparrow - face gray, not olive, face pattern different, overall shaped different (long floppy tails)
Savannah Sparrow - overall shape different, face and nape not olive.
Grasshopper Sparrow - juvenile has streaked breast but lacks whisker marks, crown-stripe whitish, back ground color, face and nape not olive, nape streaked not clear
Sharp-tailed and LeConte's - different face pattern, both lack whisker marks, nape also different color

What is your prior experience with this and similarly appearing species?

Lincoln's, Grasshopper, and Savannah Sparrow often seen, warmer months (Colorado and elsewhere)
Daird's and Sharp-tailed - seen few times; Colorado and coastal Virginia respectively

List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: Wade Leitner, National Geographic Field Guide

b) after observation: Aud. Master Guide, Charlie Chase, specimens at Denver Museum of N.H.

This report was written from reports made during X, after observation _____ from memory _____
Date and time report was written: 1-14-86 12:30 pm

Reporting observer: Laurens R. Halsey Signature: Laurens R. Halsey

Address: 6422 Bluebird Ave. Longmont, CO 80501

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DENVER MUSEUM OF NATURAL HISTORY
CITY PARK
DENVER, CO 80205



Museum of Natural Science
Research Division: Museum of Zoology
LOUISIANA STATE UNIVERSITY AND AGRICULTURAL AND MECHANICAL COLLEGE
BATON ROUGE · LOUISIANA · 70803-3216
504388-2855

4 March 1986

Mr. Peter Gent
C.F.O. Bird Records Comm.
55 S. 35th St.
Boulder, Colo. 80303

FROM VAN REMSEN

Dear Peter:

Thanks for the opportunity to look at the Henslow's Sparrow report from Jackson Reservoir. From the written reports of Laurens Halsey and Wade Leitner and from verbal conversations with Jack Reddall, I am reasonably certain that they did indeed see a Henslow's Sparrow.

The descriptions of plumage match closely what one sees in the field and in the hand for Henslow's Sparrow. The mostly olive face and olive collar are diagnostic. Other details are also supportive, e.g. the double whisker and the buffy & streaked breast band. The only discrepancies are those that one might expect without close-up inspection, e.g. the crown stripes are actually blackish, not brown, and the back pattern is a complex mixture of reds, blacks, and whites that would be difficult to describe accurately.

As for behavior, the few details available are mostly consistent with Henslow's, i.e. silent, still when perched in open, and taking cover in grass. What is missing is whether or not they tried to flush it up from the grass once it flew into the grass for the second time, or whether it flew up to the fence after being flushed there by the observers. In my experience with nonbreeding individuals in Louisiana, you do not see the species perched in the open unless you flush it. I have never heard of anyone just spotting a Henslow's sitting up in the open. They characteristically spend their time on the ground, in grass, and run like mice to evade people. They flush mainly when nearly stepped on. So, in order to be 100% certain, I'd like to have seen more about the circumstances of the record. Did the observers flush the bird to the fence? Did they try to flush it after the second time but were never able to do so? (This species is very good at vanishing without a trace from pursuers.) Also, the observers mention no other species associated with this individual; if indeed the bird was solitary and not associating with other sparrows, this would further support the identification as Henslow's, which is characteristically highly solitary. I would recommend contacting the observers to supply these additional points.

This is yet another example of how a complete account of the circumstances of the observation, especially with respect to the bird's behavior, greatly facilitates determinations of this kind, especially because anyone can copy details of plumage from a field guide, but the behavioral details are generally much less readily available.

Having spent many, many days birding with Jack Reddall, I know him to be one of the most careful and trustworthy observers that I've ever been with, and so his firm conviction that the bird was a Henslow's gives the record much credibility.

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Feb. 27, 1986

Dear Mr. Gent,

If the observers are careful, reliable and experienced, and it certainly sounds like they are, I would have no trouble accepting this record. Since the species seems to breed as far west as the middle of Kansas, this bird would seem to be overdue in your state.

I should also mention here that I am no expert on this species, which breeds only marginally in Minn., and my experience with it is limited to adults singing on breeding territory. But I have seen lots of Grasshopper, Le Conte's, Sharp-tailed and Baird's Sparrows, and in my opinion none of them could fit these details. While all have these can have a dark mark on the ear coverts, only the Baird's has the double malar mark. However, that species does not (to my eye) have the large bill-flat headed profile of the Henslow's; that species also lacks the short narrow tail of the Henslow's — to my eye, the Baird's has a "normal", average length, notched tail. I would think the Baird's is the only species which closely resembles the Henslow's as far as its double malar mark and median stripe widening on to the nape; its dull orange color, which is often hard to see, also can extend to the side of the head and, depending on the light and how an observer describes colors, I could see this color might be called "olive". However, the olive head color of the Henslow's is really obvious and distinctive, at least in breeding plumage, and again the tail and head shapes are quite different in the Baird's.

Grasshopper, Le Conte's and Sharp-tailed can be eliminated for several reasons, so I see no reason not to accept the bird as a Henslow's. The only detail that doesn't match up with the Henslow's ~~is~~ the "fine" streaking on the underparts; I would describe this streaking on breeding plumaged Henslow's as well-defined and obvious. However, by September an adult's plumage could be worn enough to obscure the streaking and make it appear "fine".

Hope this has been of some help. Again, I'm no expert on Henslow's Sparrows, and it wouldn't surprise me if another "expert" or your committee disagreed with my opinions.

s,

ls

Kim Schult

